Volunteer Center Website Redesign – Final Documentation

BUS 119A – Fall 2025

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Client: Volunteer Center of Santa Cruz County

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Project Overview

The Volunteer Center of Santa Cruz County (VCSC) is a cornerstone of community engagement, connecting thousands of residents each year to over 300 nonprofit organizations through volunteer opportunities. These range from short-term cleanups and literacy programs to long-term commitments supporting seniors, youth, and disaster relief efforts. VCSC also manages over 20 in-house programs that rely heavily on efficient volunteer coordination, making a reliable and accessible digital platform essential for its mission.

Currently, VCSC operates two major online systems:

- **Main Website (www.scvolunteercenter.org)** – a modern, mobile-responsive, and easy-to-update site that highlights programs and news.
- **Volunteer Database (www.scvolunteernow.org)** – hosted on Salesforce's HandsOn Connect platform, which manages volunteer registrations, opportunities, and partner organization listings.

The problem lies in the disparity between the two platforms. While the main site is visually appealing and aligned with the organization's brand, the HandsOn Connect portal feels outdated and inconsistent. The user interface lacks cohesion, and the site presents accessibility issues, particularly with contrast, font readability, and mobile navigation. Since most volunteers access the site from mobile devices, these issues create real barriers for users.

Originally, the project goal was to redesign and enhance the HandsOn Connect platform so the volunteer portal could better match the main site's branding and provide a more modern, accessible experience. However, due to limited time left in the semester and the need to maintain platform stability, direct editing access cannot be granted.

Updated Project Direction

Instead of implementing changes in the live Salesforce environment, this project now focuses entirely on creating clear, organized documentation that the Volunteer Center can use after the semester ends.

This documentation includes:

- Mockups and visual redesign recommendations
- Accessibility and usability improvements
- Navigation and layout suggestions
- A list of design changes confirmed possible within HandsOn Connect
- Open questions or items requiring vendor support

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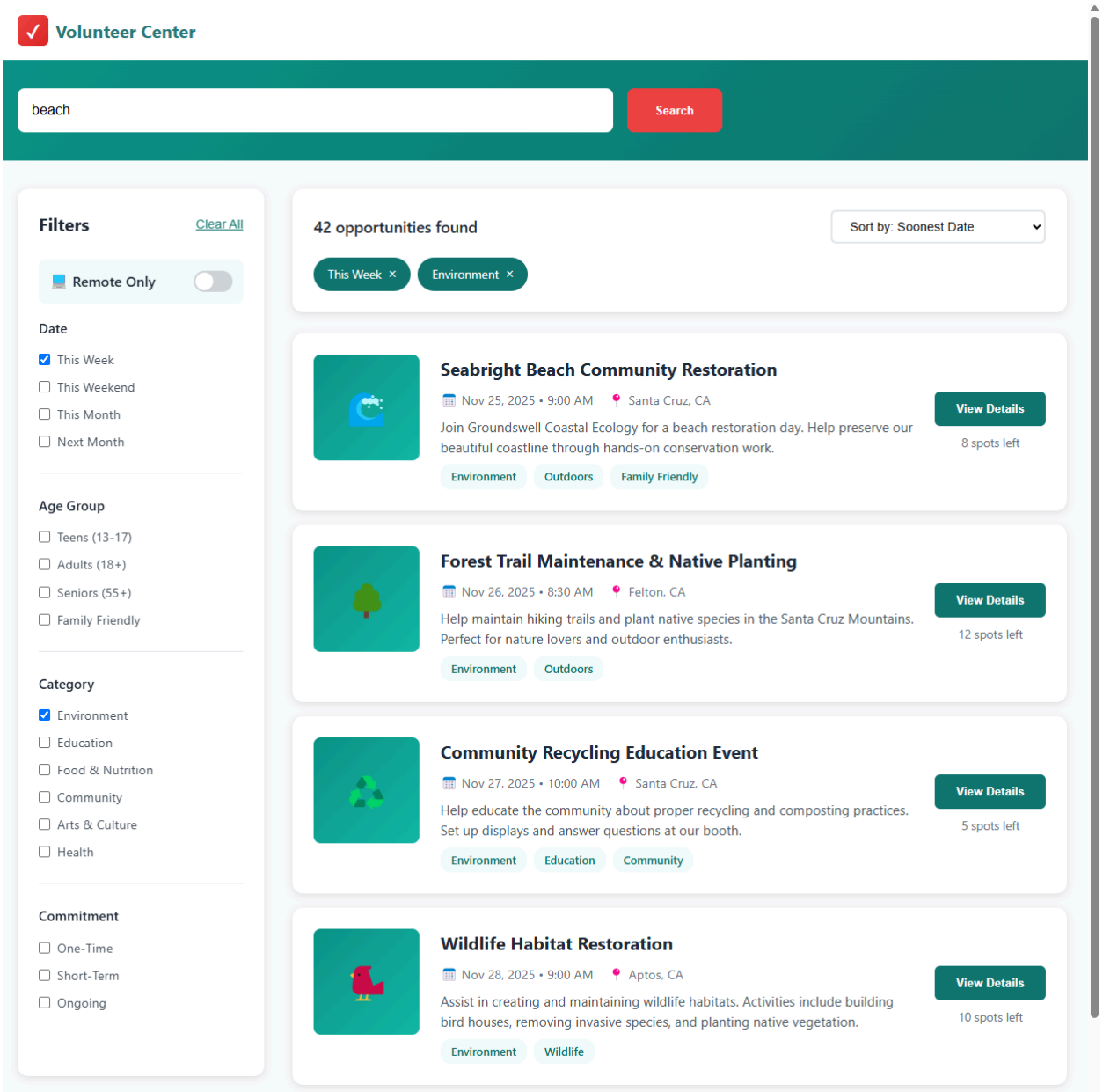
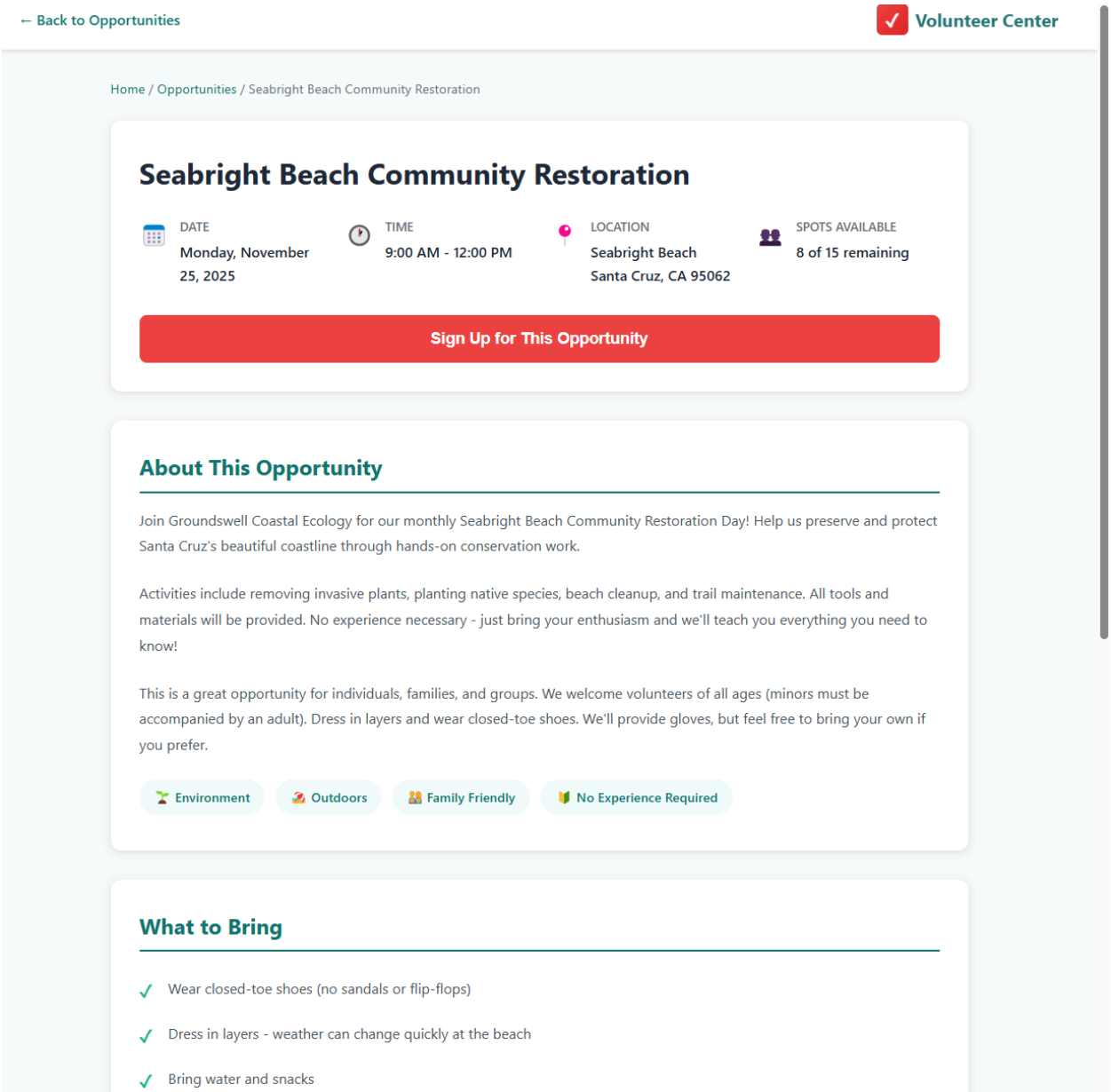
1. Mockups & Visual Recommendations

1. Have High Contrasting buttons for important ones such as Volunteer now, Donate, etc

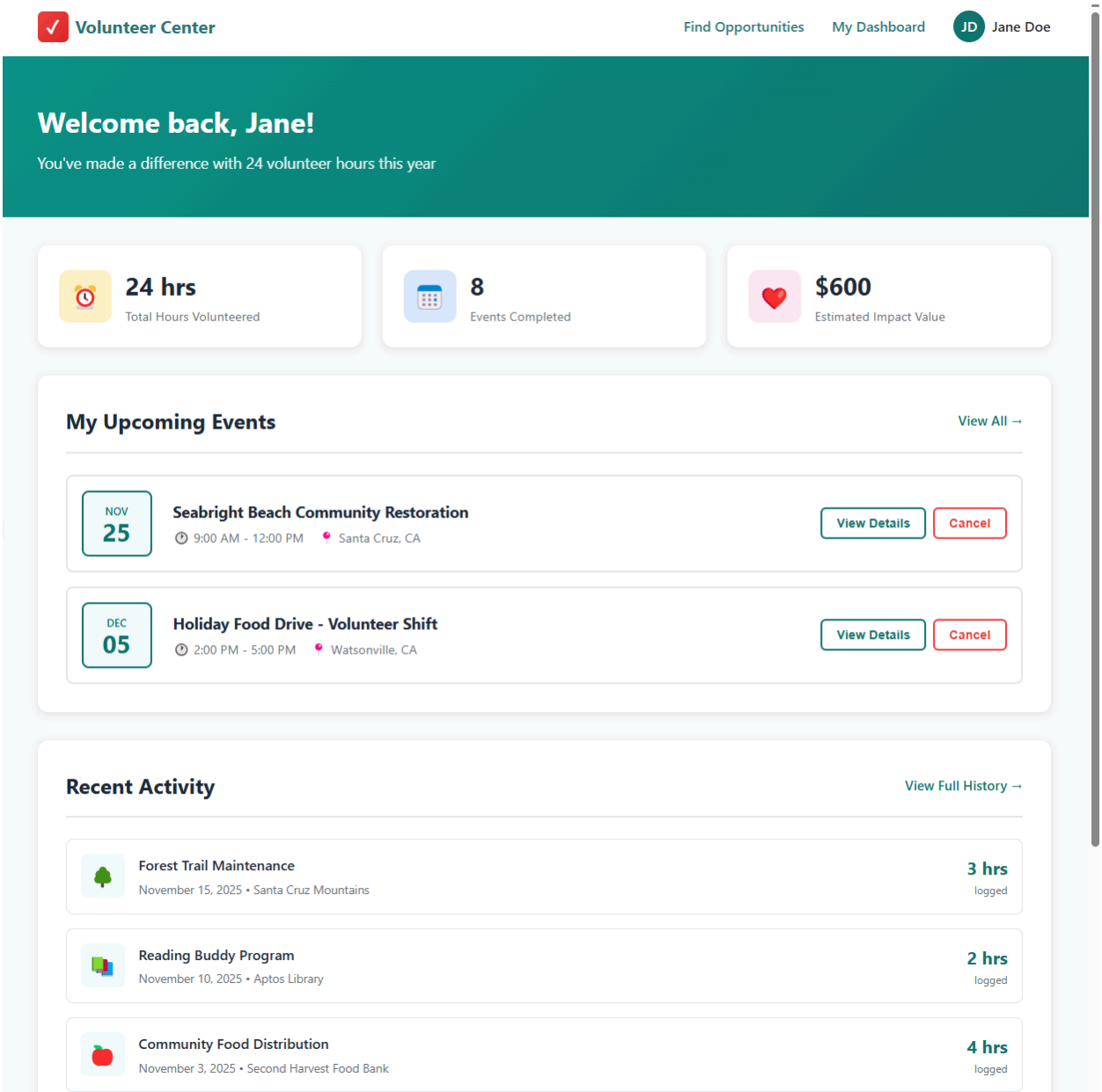
2. Navigation and Accessibility



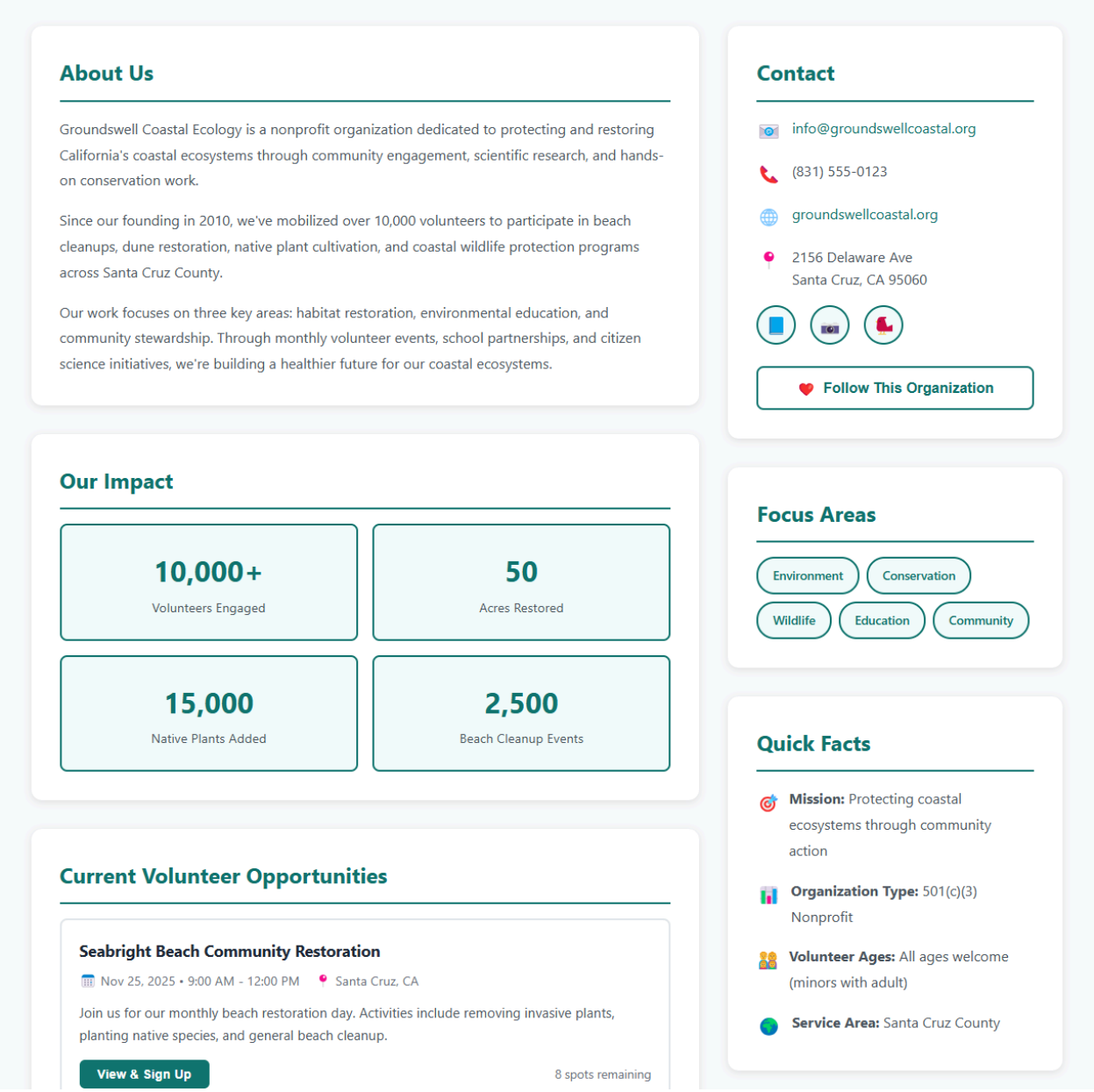
3. Opportunity Details page when clicking into an event



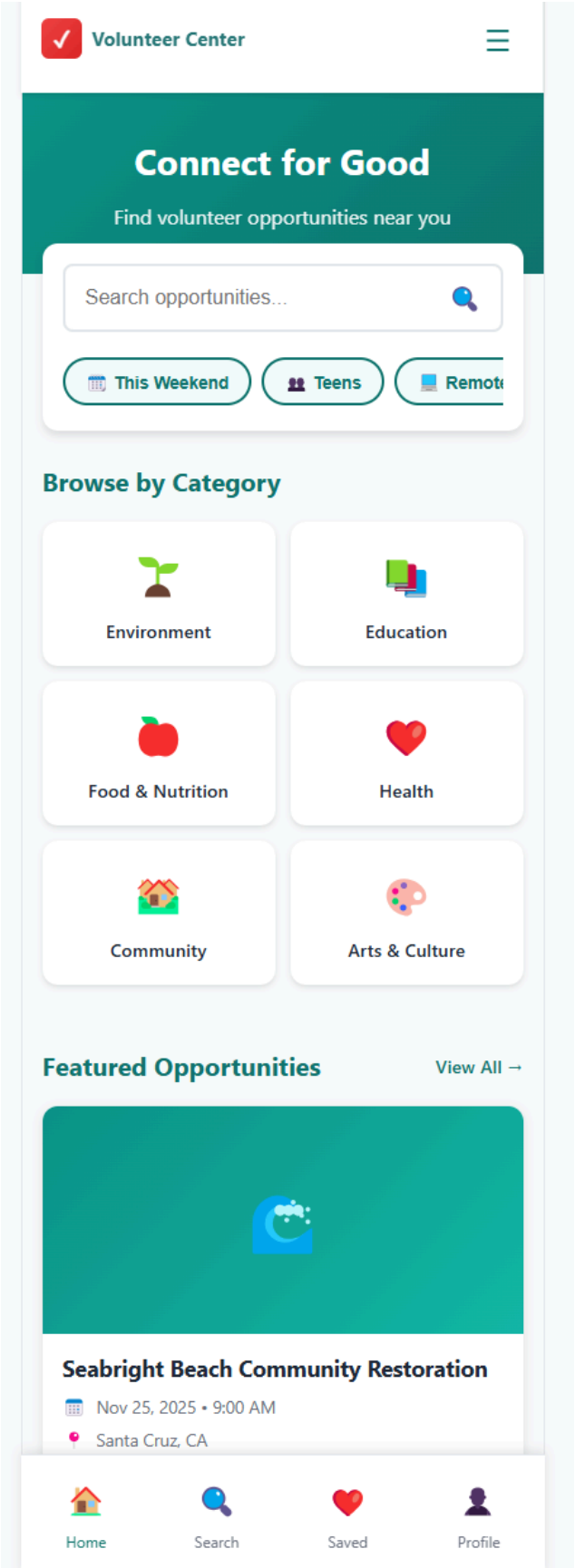
4. User Personalized Dashboards which are extremely engaging



5. Organization Profile Page



5. As for mobile here is the homepage


Volunteer Center
Connect for Good
Find volunteer opportunities near you
Search opportunities...
This Weekend
Teens
Remote
Browse by Category
Environment
Education
Food & Nutrition
Health
Community
Arts & Culture
Featured Opportunities
View All →
Seabright Beach Community Restoration
Nov 25, 2025 • 9:00 AM
Santa Cruz, CA
Home
Search
Saved
Profile

2. Accessibility & Usability Improvements

Below are the key accessibility and usability improvements recommended for the HandsOn Connect volunteer portal. These suggestions come from reviewing both the current portal and the main Volunteer Center website and identifying areas where the user experience, clarity, and ADA/WCAG compliance can be improved.

Improve Readability

The portal currently has some inconsistencies that makes content harder to read, especially for seniors, mobile users, and users with low vision.

Recommended improvements:

- Increase the default font size across the site (16–18px for body text).
- Use consistent font styles and spacing.
- Fix color contrast issues between text and background.
- Ensure all images and icons have alt-text for screen readers.
- Improve heading structure (H1 → H2 → H3) to support accessibility and navigation.

Improve Mobile Experience

Most of the site's layout doesn't adjust well to mobile devices, making forms and listings very difficult to navigate.

Recommended improvements:

- Increase button/click target sizes.
- Fix layout overlap issues in the menu and search bar.
- Make the "Sign Up" button visible without scrolling too much.
- Improve spacing so content doesn't feel cramped.

Make the Portal Visually Consistent With the Main Website

The HandsOn Connect portal looks completely different from the main Volunteer Center site, which can confuse users and makes the experience feel disconnected.

Recommended improvements:

- Match the color palette to the main site (teal + white + red accent).
- Update the header and footer so both sites look unified.
- Use a modern, clean layout instead of the older teal blocks.
- Simplify the header and make the menu easier to see.

Simplify the Homepage Layout

The current homepage is visually overwhelming and doesn't clearly guide users on what to do.

Recommended improvements:

- Add a simple, prominent search bar at the top.
- Introduce quick filter chips like "Weekend," "Teens," "Remote," etc.
- Use consistent volunteer opportunity cards with:
  - a clean image
  - short title
  - short summary
  - one clear button ("View Opportunity")
- Highlight a small Featured Opportunities section.

Improve the Opportunity Details Page

The current opportunity pages are cluttered and hard to scan.

Recommended improvements:

- Move essential details (title, date, time, location, summary) to the top.
- Add icons for readability:

    - calendar → date
    - clock → time
    - pin → address
- Make the “Sign Up” button large and visible.
- Move long descriptions and instructions lower on the page.

Improve Search Results

The results page is busy, and users have trouble finding opportunities quickly.

Recommended improvements:

- Default sorting to “Soonest Date”.
- Make the filter options more visible and easier to reset.
- Use smaller, cleaner opportunity cards so more fit on screen.
- Add filter chips that show what the user has selected.

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3. Navigation & Layout Changes

Improving Navigation and layout will make it significantly easier for volunteers to browse opportunities, and understand where to go, while still engaging with the platform with no confusion. These recommendations focus on improving structure flow, rather then styling or accessibility.

A. Navigation Bar (Top Menu)

- Make the top menu match the main website so it feels consistent.
- Clean up the menu names so they’re easier to understand.
- Put the less important links under a “More” menu so the header isn’t crowded.
- Add a clear “Volunteer Today” button at the top so people know where to start.
- On mobile, use simple dropdowns so it doesn’t feel messy.

B. Homepage Layout

- Add a big search bar near the top so people can start looking right away.
- Add quick filter buttons like Weekend, Remote, Teens, One-Day, etc.
- Show a Featured Opportunities section to highlight the important ones.
- Add a simple “Browse by Category” area so users don’t have to guess where to look.
- Clean up the layout and give everything more spacing so it doesn’t feel cramped.

C. Opportunity Cards

- Use one consistent style for every opportunity card.
- Make all images the same size (3:2 looks best).
- Keep cards simple:

  image → title → date/time → short summary → button
- Make the button text consistent (“View & Sign Up”).
- Give cards more spacing so they’re easier to scan.

D. Opportunity Detail Page

- Put the most important info at the top (title, date, time, location).
- Add small icons for things like date/time/location to make it easier to scan.
- Make the Sign Up button bigger and always in the same spot.
- Move long paragraphs lower on the page so the top section is clean.
- On mobile, keep the Sign Up button sticky so users don’t have to scroll back up.

E. Search & Filter Page

- Make the default sort Soonest (or something similar).

- Show selected filters as little chips users can click to remove.
- Add an easy Remote toggle.
- Clean up the filter sidebar and make it expandable on mobile.
- Use smaller, cleaner cards so users can see more results at once.

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4. Design Change We know are Possible In Hands-on Connect

Based on what we've seen in HandsOn Connect and what other orgs using the same system are doing, here's what we know is actually possible to update. These are the changes that don't need deep access or custom development and are supported by the platform.

A. Visual + Branding Changes (Confirmed Possible)

- Updating the colors to match the main site
- Changing button styles and hover effects
- Adjusting font sizes and overall spacing
- Updating header and footer text/links
- Replacing images and controlling image shape/ratio
- Changing background colors and cleaning up sections
- Rewriting all text and content blocks
- Using simple HTML inside certain areas (icons, spacing, dividers)

Basically, the look and feel can be made way more modern without needing code.

B. Page Layout Adjustments (Confirmed Possible)

- Rearranging the order of content on key pages
- Editing how opportunity titles/descriptions show
- Adjusting the layout of the homepage hero section

- Making featured opportunities show up higher on the page
- Shortening or reorganizing the opportunity card content
- Changing the default sort order on the search page (Soonest/This Month)
- Adding icons in some sections using HTML blocks

The structure isn't 100% customizable, but there's enough flexibility to make it look cleaner.

C. Navigation Updates (Confirmed Possible)

- Renaming menu items
- Changing the order of the links
- Highlighting important buttons like "Volunteer Today"
- Updating the footer links to match the main website
- Cleaning up mobile navigation labels

HandsOn Connect lets you adjust the menus, just not replace the whole template.

D. Mobile-Friendly Improvements (Partially Supported)

These are things we *can* improve, but only within the template limits:

- Fixing spacing and reducing cramped areas
- Making text bigger for mobile
- Cleaning up sections that overflow off-screen
- Improving readability in mobile views

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5. Open Questions / Items Requiring Vendor Support

Even though we were able to figure out a lot about what HandsOn Connect can do, there are still some things we weren't able to confirm because we didn't have full backend or template access. These are potential question the volunteer center may need to ask HandsOn Connect support for.

A. Template + Layout Questions

These depend on what template the portal is currently using and what features are unlocked:

- Can the site be switched to a newer or more flexible HandsOn Connect template?
- Are there any layout options (like wider sections or more modern block layouts) that aren't currently enabled?
- Can the homepage hero section be edited beyond basic text + image areas?

B. CSS + Styling Limits

We weren't able to see what level of CSS the system allows:

- Is there a way to apply global CSS so changes apply to every page?
- Or is CSS only allowed in certain content blocks?
- Can we adjust global spacing/padding, or only inside specific pages?

C. Navigation + Menu Customization

The top menu can be edited, but some things might be locked:

- Can the Volunteer Center add a "mega menu" style dropdown (like the main website uses)?
- Are there limits on how many links can appear in the navigation bar?
- Can the mobile menu be fully customized, or only partially?

D. Search + Filters

Some search and filtering options may rely on backend settings:

- Can HandsOn Connect support filter "chips" (like Weekend, Teens, Remote) natively?
- Is there a way to add a dedicated "Remote Only" toggle?

- Can the default sort order be locked to “Soonest” for all users?

E. Opportunity Cards + Icons

We know basic edits are possible, but these might need vendor help:

- Can icons (calendar, clock, location pin, etc.) be added globally to all opportunity pages?
- Can we adjust how much text displays on cards before the “View More” button?
- Are there settings to force all images into a consistent crop?

F. Mobile Behavior

Some mobile features may or may not be supported:

- Can a sticky “Sign Up” button be enabled on mobile?
- Can certain sections be collapsed/expanded automatically on smaller screens?
- Is there a way to hide desktop-only elements from mobile users?